

Performance

Gaming

In *FarCry*, while the Gigabyte i-DNA GA-8I955X Royal topped the table with 134.79 fps at 1024 x 768, the MSI P4N SLI topped with 107.47 fps at the higher resolution of 1600 x 1200. Not far behind was the MSI P4N Diamond, which scored 107.25 fps at 1600 x 1200. In the *Doom 3* benchmark, the MSI P4N SLI was the top scorer with the P4N Diamond following closely at both resolutions. Hence these are better motherboards for gamers.

Synthetic Benchmarks

In 3DMark05, the MSI P4N SLI was again the top scorer, with 7037 marks—so, along with gaming, this board is good for multimedia applications such as Maya and 3D Studio Max.

PCMark 2004 is a system-wide test. The top scorer here was yet again the MSI P4N SLI, again closely followed by the MSI P4N Diamond. In almost all the sub-tests here, the P4N SLI fared well, and so can be considered a board around which a system with good overall performance can be built.

In SiSoft Sandra 2005, the memory bandwidth scores were almost the same for most of the boards, and so there was no clear winner. In the CPU benchmarks, the ASUS P5AD2-E Premium, Gigabyte i-DNA GA-8I945G Pro and MSI P4N SLI were the better performers, and there wasn't much difference between these three.

Real-World benchmarks

In video encoding, again, there wasn't much difference between the boards. The encoding time ranged from 118 to 121 seconds, which is not sufficient to make a decision about which board is better. Hence, for video encoding applications, any of these boards would be as good as the other.

In the ZDBench Business Winstone 2004 test, the ASUS P5ND2-SLI Deluxe scored 26.6, followed very closely by the MSI P4N SLI with 26.3. Since this is a real-world test—it reflects real-world performance—the high-scoring motherboards are the ones which will perform better in office and similar applications.

The Conclusion (Intel Motherboards)

When we're talking about features, the MSI P4N Diamond was the best, with nice bundled accessories such as the Bluetooth and Wi-Fi combo card and the on-board Creative Sound-Blaster Live! 24-bit sound chip. Also good on the features front was the ASUS Proactive P5ND2-SLI Deluxe, which bundled some good accessories and an external SATA port.

Performance-wise, the ASUS P5ND2-SLI Deluxe, Gigabyte GA-8I955X, MSI P4N Diamond and MSI P4N SLI were almost neck-and-neck. But the Giga-

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MSI P4N-SLI.

byte GA-8I955X was the highest-priced motherboard at Rs 17,950, and the MSI P4N Diamond is at Rs 17,500. The ASUS P5LD2-VM was the least expensive at Rs 7,200, but this board was also the one with the lowest feature points.

We took features, performance and price into account, as always, and the *Digit* Best Buy Gold winner was the MSI P4N Diamond.

Deciding the Silver winner was a problem because two boards scored almost the same in the final tally. So a tie it was to be, and the *Digit* Best Buy Silver goes jointly to the ASUS Proactive P5ND2-SLI Deluxe and the MSI P4N SLI.

The Overall Conclusion

A motherboard is as important a component of a computer as the CPU, and is a major contributing factor to the general performance and features you can access on a PC. After all, it is the *mother*-board.

We tested twenty high-end, cutting-edge motherboards on which you can really enjoy gaming as well as entertainment, and on which you get rich high-definition audio. These boards are all made to perfectly complement high-end processors such as dual-cores, and high-end peripherals such as PCIe graphics cards, low-latency RAM and high-speed SATA II hard drives—delivering the best performance any enthusiast could hope for.

Some motherboards such as the DFI LanParty are specifically targeted at, as the name suggests, avid gamers. If you're wondering, a LAN party is when a group of gamers come together—usually over the weekend—with their gaming rigs which they hook up to a LAN, and play as long as they possibly can. Because it is a party, (junk) food and drink is always involved, along with lots of multi-player games.

Several of the boards we've tested featured nVidia's SLI interface, which is sure to become the norm of the future. Similarly, ATI's CrossFire (which is similar to nVidia's SLI, but which is more flexible and which supports only ATI's PCIe graphics cards) is expected to arrive soon, and time will tell whether SLI and CrossFire will happily coexist—or whether there will be an all-out battle. ☒

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Contact Sheet

Motherboards

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Gigabyte	Gigabyte Technology (India) Ltd	022-26526696	sales@gigabyte.in	www.gigabyte.in
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